all was the crabby Brigadier Shelton, who quarrelled with almost every one of the other prisoners. Even when they were all nearly killed by an earthquake on 19 February, Shelton found a way to use it as a pretext for an argument. When the earthquake struck, he happened to be sitting on a bench with Mackenzie on the flat roof of the fort:

> He looked around fiercely to see who was shaking his bench. Mackenzie cried: 'It's an earthquake Brigadier!' and, calling to Lady Sale, made for the stairs, which were cracking and falling about them, and by God's mercy, they all reached the bottom in safety. In the evening Shelton came up and said: 'Mackenzie, I want to speak to you.' 'Very well, Brigadier.' In a solemn tone, to make him feel the enormity of offence [he said]: 'Mackenzie, you went downstairs first today'; to which the latter coolly replied: 'It's the fashion in an earthquake Brigadier. I learned it among the Spaniards in Manila.'[30]

Lady Sale, meanwhile, took the earthquake with her usual spirit: 'The roof of our room fell in with a dreadful crash. The roof of the stairs fell in as I descended them; but did me no injury. All my anxiety was for Mrs Sturt; but I could only see a heap of rubbish. I was nearly bewildered, when I heard the joyful sound, "Lady Sale come here, all are safe"; and found the whole party uninjured in the courtyard . . . Lady M's cat', she added, 'was buried in the ruins, but dug out again.'[31]

On that same morning, 19 February, Thomas Seaton had been sent out of the south gate of Jalalabad with a pickaxe to lead a working party.

He and his men had been ordered to destroy some ruined mud walls just outside the city. The walls had provided cover for groups of Afghan cavalry who had been harassing the foraging parties the British daily sent out to gather fodder, and Seaton was told to knock them down so as to provide a clear line of shot for the cannon on the gate and make the whole sector safer for the grass-cutting syces [grooms] and haymaking camp followers. There was some urgency to this work and Seaton had strict instructions to finish it before sundown as the British had learned from their spies that Akbar Khan and his army were now only a day's ride away from Jalalabad: having deposited his prisoners of war beyond rescue by the British – or abduction by his rivals – Akbar was now returning to finish off the remaining British presence in the country.

A little after eleven o'clock, Seaton had put down his pickaxe and was admiring the view down the valley when he felt a faint shaking beneath his